Since making her Hindi acting debut with *Dil Maange More* in 2004, Soha Ali Khan has played a variety of roles: a black-and-white era actress, an international studies student mourning the sudden death of her fiancé, and so on. Whether it was due to the film industry's limited imagination or the result of being typecast, the actor never ended up playing an antagonist. It took her almost two decades to tick that off her bucket list.

In Vishal Furia's *Chhorii 2*—a sequel to the 2021 horror film—that released on Prime Video this month, Khan goes a step beyond being an antagonist, playing the most menacing character of her career. When the script came her way, Khan had already watched *Chhorii*, which revolved around a pregnant woman (played by Nushrratt Bharuccha) tasked with saving her unborn child from evil spirits. The 46-year-old resonated with the social messaging embedded in the fabric of the film. "What drew me to the film was the way it blended atmospheric horror with folklore," Khan tells INDIA TODAY. She found the script for the sequel equally compelling, "I could imagine the eerie background music when Vishal narrated it to me."




In Vishal Furia's **CHHORII 2**, Soha Ali Khan goes a step beyond being an antagonist, playing the most menacing character of her career

By her own admission, the decision to join *Chhorii 2*—which picks up the action seven years later—as the sinister Daasi Maa, was a no-brainer. It helped that Khan was an avid horror fan and saw in the film an opportunity to test her mettle as an actor. Still, she didn't account for the fact that her transformation into Daasi Maa would prove to be a physically demanding affair. "At one point on set, I remember feeling glad that I had been going to the gym because there was a lot of core strength that I had to employ to balance myself. I was often dressed up in a thick black material with my hands bound and then suspended from the ceiling to give the illusion of Daasi Maa flying or moving through space very quickly in a limbless form."

Indeed, the genre is known to be unsettling and provocative. When done well, horror films can possess the kind of terrifying profundity that tends to stay with you much longer than other films. Khan agrees with the assessment. "They can really invade your mental space and wake you up in the middle of the night. So, I feel that if you want to make an impact as an actor, what better way to do that than through horror?"

That's not to suggest that Khan is an actor prone to making calculated moves. *Chhorii 2*, for instance, marks the actor's return to Hindi film after six years. But the milestone doesn't appear to mean much to her. The way she explains her absence from movies is that she is not one to put on herself the need to have three or four releases a year. "It's also because I enjoy my life and the different roles that I play in it." Being a professional actor, Khan underlines, is just one part of her life, not her entire life. "If I don't